

Clinical Institute Withdrawal Assessment for Alcohol (CIWA-Ar) Scale(1)(2)(3)

Assess and rate each of the 10 criteria of the CIWA scale. Each criterion is rated on a scale from 0 (least severe) to 7 (most severe) except for "Orientation and clouding of sensorium," which is rated on a scale from 0 to 4. Add up the scores for all 10 criteria. This is the total CIWA-Ar score for the patient at that time.

***Nausea/Vomiting** - Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ None (+0)
- ☐ Mild nausea with no vomiting (+1)
- ☐ (+2)
- ☐ (+3)
- ☐ Intermittent nausea (+4)
- ☐ (+5)
- ☐ (+6)
- ☐ Constant nausea and frequent dry heaves and vomiting (+7)

***Tremors** - Have patient extend arms and spread fingers. Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ No tremor (+0)
- ☐ Not visible, but can be felt fingertip to fingertip (+1)
- ☐ (+2)
- ☐ (+3)
- ☐ Moderate, with patient's arms extended (+4)
- ☐ (+5)
- ☐ (+6)
- ☐ Severe, even with arms not extended (+7)

***Anxiety** - Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ No anxiety, patient at ease (+0)
- ☐ Mildly anxious (+1)
- ☐ (+2)
- ☐ (+3)
- ☐ Moderately anxious or guarded, so anxiety is inferred (+4)
- ☐ (+5)
- ☐ (+6)
- ☐ Equivalent to acute panic states seen in severe delirium or acute schizophrenic reactions (+7)

***Agitation** - Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ Normal activity (+0)
- ☐ Somewhat normal activity (+1)
- ☐ (+2)
- ☐ (+3)
- ☐ Moderately fidgety and restless (+4)
- ☐ (+5)
- ☐ (+6)
- ☐ Paces back and forth or constantly thrashes about (+7)

***Paroxysmal sweats** - Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ No sweats (+0)

- ☐ Barely perceptible sweating, palms moist (+1)
- ☐ (+2)
- ☐ (+3)
- ☐ Beads of sweat obvious on forehead (+4)
- ☐ (+5)
- ☐ (+6)
- ☐ Drenching sweats (+7)

***Orientation and clouding of sensorium** - Ask, "What day is this? Where are you? Who am I?" Rate scale 0 to 4.

- ☐ Oriented (+0)
- ☐ Cannot do serial additions or is uncertain about date (+1)
- ☐ Disoriented to date by no more than 2 calendar days (+2)
- ☐ Disoriented to date by more than 2 calendar days (+3)
- ☐ Disoriented to place and/or person (+4)

***Tactile disturbances** - Ask, "Have you experienced any itching, pins and needles sensation, burning or numbness, or a feeling of bugs crawling on or under your skin?" Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ None (+0)
- ☐ Very mild itching, pins and needles, burning, or numbness (+1)
- ☐ Mild itching, pins and needles, burning, or numbness (+2)
- ☐ Moderate itching, pins and needles, burning, or numbness (+3)
- ☐ Moderate hallucinations (+4)
- ☐ Severe hallucinations (+5)
- ☐ Extremely severe hallucinations (+6)
- ☐ Continuous hallucinations (+7)

***Auditory disturbances** - Ask, "Are you more aware of sounds around you? Are they harsh? Do they startle you? Do you hear anything that disturbs you or that you know isn't there?" Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ Not present (+0)
- ☐ Very mild harshness or ability to startle (+1)
- ☐ Mild harshness or ability to startle (+2)
- ☐ Moderate harshness or ability to startle (+3)
- ☐ Moderate hallucinations (+4)
- ☐ Severe hallucinations (+5)
- ☐ Extremely severe hallucinations (+6)
- ☐ Continuous hallucinations (+7)

***Visual disturbances** - Ask, "Does the light appear to be too bright? Is its color different than normal? Does it hurt your eyes? Are you seeing anything that disturbs you or that you know isn't there?" Rate on scale 0 to 7.

- ☐ Not present (+0)
- ☐ Very mild sensitivity (+1)
- ☐ Mild sensitivity (+2)
- ☐ Moderate sensitivity (+3)
- ☐ Moderate hallucinations (+4)
- ☐ Severe hallucinations (+5)
- ☐ Extremely severe hallucinations (+6)
- ☐ Continuous hallucinations (+7)

***Headache** - Ask, "Does your head feel different than usual? Does it feel like there is a band around your head?" Rate on scale 0 to 7. Do not rate dizziness or lightheadedness.

- ☐ Not present (+0)
- ☐ Very mild (+1)
- ☐ Mild (+2)
- ☐ Moderate (+3)
- ☐ Moderately severe (+4)
- ☐ Severe (+5)
- ☐ Very severe (+6)
- ☐ Extremely severe (+7)

Score: 67

Scale for scoring: This score should be used in conjunction with clinical judgment to assess the severity of alcohol withdrawal.

Score of 0 to 9: **Mild** withdrawal

Score of 10 to 18: **Moderate** withdrawal

Score of 19 or higher (absence of seizure, delirium, hallucinations): **Severe** withdrawal

Score of 19 or higher (presence of seizure, delirium, or new-onset hallucinations): **Complicated** withdrawal